shadow over the global economy.[47] Lou Jiwei, a former Chinese finance minister, stated recently that “A Sino–US trade war could ease somewhat but wider conflicts between the world’s two largest economies will continue.”[48] The rising tensions with the United States are informing China to establish closer economic ties with India,[49] and Modi appears to be prioritising an improvement of India–China relations.

India joining the SCO has started a process of building mutual trust between the two nations, but India’s improved ties with China could hardly be construed as a sign of an evolving policy harmonisation process, and India still needs to be watchful about duplicitous moves by Pakistan and China in the SCO.

Just as India will have to get used to a new order with China as a major player, China on its part will have to eventually shed its misgivings and get used to the growing US–India defence ties. What gave the SCO Qingdao Summit additional punch is the geopolitical shift underway in Asia and the strategic formulation of the “Quad” and the “Indo-Pacific” idea by the United States, Japan, India, and Australia. India can always argue that its growing ties with the United States are not meant to target others. In fact, Pakistan’s status as a “major non-NATO ally” never got in the way of China–Pakistan military ties. Similarly, New Delhi’s closer ties with Washington ought not to prevent it from boosting ties with Russia and China.

Conclusion

This chapter clearly shows that India’s motivation for joining the SCO is driven by a wide range of factors and includes an ambition to build bridges with Central Asia, access